

BIG SLIP AAP leaders Atishi, Kejriwal and Bhagwant Mann during the Delhi poll campaign

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AAP

AAP GUARDS FORT PUNJAB

By Avishek G. Dastidar and Anilesh S. Mahajan

For Arvind Kejriwal, the question is not whether the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has a future in Delhi—it's whether the party can continue to remain relevant as an idea in national politics. In a half-hour meeting with 86 of the 95 AAP MLAs of Punjab led by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on February 11, three days after the party's rout in Delhi, Kejriwal apparently let on what he has in mind for the party's future.

Those present at the meeting said the main focus would be to keep alive the "AAP model of governance" carefully created over a decade's rule in Delhi. Think schools, hospitals, free power et al. The message to the MLAs was simple: now that it doesn't have Delhi anymore, Punjab will have to serve as the AAP canvas for the country to see. The border state will be going to polls in two years—so Punjab can expect to see a lot more of Kejriwal now than it did in the past five years, say sources. Going forward, also expect good chances for that association to be formalised: there is talk in AAP ranks about Kejriwal getting himself nominated to the Rajya Sabha through the Punjab route. This will give him the eyeballs he needs on the national stage, and proximity to national allies. Punjab sends seven parliamentarians to the Upper House. All are AAP members now.

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In politics, though, things are rarely what they seem. Many felt the meeting was called as a show of unity by the high command—a "roll call" of sorts to make sure the Punjab unit is intact. That's top priority at the moment, with Congress leaders in the state openly claiming that a number of AAP MLAs would now jump ship, a claim that CM Mann has to take pains to dismiss all too often.

The Punjab Congress's glee was there for all to see on Feb. 8 after news came that AAP had been cut down to 22 seats in the 70-member Delhi assembly, and that Kejriwal himself had lost his seat. No matter that the Congress itself failed to open its account in the national capital and managed less